

SLO1

Theories of Second Language Acquisition and Grammar

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A linguistics tutor who meets students in a coffee shop on Saturdays asks how many morphemes are in the word “unhelpfully.” The word appeared on a 20-item quiz. What is the answer?

- A. 1
- B. 5
- C. 3
- D. 4

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which suffix is inflectional rather than derivational?

- A. -ness in “kindness”
- B. -ed in “walked”
- C. -ly in “quickly”
- D. -er in “teacher”

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A teacher in a school with a new robotics lab shares the headline “Teacher sees student with binoculars” to show ambiguity. The headline came from a mock newspaper her class printed. Why does the sentence have two meanings?

- A. Headlines leave out articles, which always makes them ambiguous.
- B. The phrase “with binoculars” can attach to “sees” (the teacher uses them) or to “student” (the student has them).
- C. The newspaper was printed by students.
- D. The word “sees” has two dictionary meanings.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

In a math class that uses a new online platform, an ELL who knows the word “table” as furniture is confused by “Complete the table.” The platform has 300 practice sets. What is the best explanation?

- A. The student does not know the word “table.”
- B. The platform uses the wrong word.
- C. “Table” is polysemous; the student needs the math meaning taught in context.
- D. “Table” has a negative connotation in math.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A linguist who has recorded speech in 12 communities notes that many English speakers say “Who did you call?” though some style guides require “Whom did you call?” The recordings were made over five years. Which statement reflects a descriptive view?

- A. “Whom” is the only correct form.
- B. Speakers who say “who” have no grammar.
- C. The question is about semantics, not grammar.
- D. “Who” is a normal object form in many speakers’ grammar.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which statement is an example of prescriptive grammar?

- A. “Many speakers end questions with prepositions, as in ‘Who are you talking to?’”
- B. “Never end a sentence with a preposition.”
- C. “English adjectives usually come before nouns.”
- D. “Children learn past-tense forms gradually.”

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A student whose family runs a bakery consistently says “She be working after school” to mean she regularly works then. The student sits near the classroom window. How should the teacher view and respond to this?

- A. The student should stop using the dialect at home too.
- B. It is lazy English and should be corrected every time.
- C. It is a random error and will go away on its own.
- D. It is a rule-governed dialect feature; teach when to use the academic form while respecting the home dialect.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A student uses her home dialect with friends at lunch and standard academic English in a class presentation. What does this show?

- A. Code-switching, a sign of skilled language use
- B. Confusion between two languages
- C. Proof that her dialect is not a real language variety
- D. Fossilization of errors

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A newcomer from a culture where children show respect by looking down when an adult speaks avoids eye contact with his teacher. He arrived in January and joined the soccer team. The teacher thinks he is being disrespectful. What is the best interpretation?

- A. He is following a cultural norm of respect; the teacher should learn about it and explain classroom expectations kindly.
- B. He is shy because he is new to the team.
- C. He does not understand English.
- D. He is being disrespectful and should be disciplined.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A researcher with a lab of four graduate students notes that toddlers say things like “Mommy sock” and “allgone milk,” phrases adults never say. The study used a new recording app. Which theory does this evidence support most?

- A. Nativist theory: children build grammar from an innate capacity, not just imitation.
- B. Sociocultural theory: children learn only through adult scaffolding.
- C. Behaviorist theory: children imitate what adults say.
- D. The recording app mis-transcribed the speech.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which piece of evidence best supports behaviorist theory?

- A. A child learns new words while building a puzzle with an older sibling.
- B. Children say “goed” though no adult says it.
- C. A child starts saying “please” more often after being praised each time she uses it.
- D. Children worldwide go through similar stages at similar ages.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A Spanish-speaking learner who writes in a journal every morning often writes “the car red” and “a house big.” Her teacher uses a color-coded grammar chart. What is the best explanation?

- A. First-language influence is always harmful, so she should stop using Spanish.
- B. She does not know the words “red” or “big.”
- C. Negative transfer from Spanish word order, where most adjectives follow the noun.
- D. Overgeneralization of an English rule.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A linguistics tutor ~~who meets students in a coffee shop on Saturdays~~ asks how many morphemes are in the word “unhelpfully.” The word appeared ~~on a 20-item quiz~~. What is the answer?

Target word: morpheme count **Decides:** un- + help + -ful + -ly.

A	Adjacent category	Counts the whole word; a word can contain many morphemes.
B	Confusion set	Splits a unit such as “-ly” or “help” into pieces that carry no meaning of their own.
C	Dropped element	Drops one affix, usually -ful or -ly.
D	Correct	un-, help, -ful, and -ly each carry meaning.

2. Answer B Concept 1 • transfer

Which suffix is inflectional rather than derivational?

Target word: classify the suffix **Decides:** Inflectional suffixes mark grammar and keep the word class.

A	Inverted operation	Derivational: turns an adjective into a noun.
B	Correct	Marks past tense; “walk” stays a verb.
C	Adjacent category	Derivational: adjective to adverb.
D	Confusion set	Derivational: verb to noun (unlike comparative -er in “taller”).

3. Answer B Concept 2

A teacher ~~in a school with a new robotics lab~~ shares the headline “Teacher sees student with binoculars” to show ambiguity. ~~The headline came from a mock newspaper her class printed.~~ Why does the sentence have two meanings?

Target word: source of ambiguity **Decides:** “With binoculars” can attach to the verb or to the noun.

A	Absolute language	Missing articles do not create these two readings.
B	Correct	Structural ambiguity: two phrase structures.
C	Camouflage	Who printed it has nothing to do with sentence structure.
D	Confusion set	That would be lexical ambiguity; the word is not the source here.

4. Answer C Concept 3

In a math class ~~that uses a new online platform~~, an ELL who knows the word “table” as furniture is confused by “Complete the table.” ~~The platform has 300 practice sets.~~ What is the best explanation?

Target word: multiple meanings **Decides:** “Table” has a subject-specific sense.

A	Dropped element	He knows one sense; the second is what is missing.
B	Camouflage	“Table” is correct math vocabulary.
C	Correct	Academic senses of common words must be taught explicitly.
D	Adjacent category	Connotation is about attitude, not a second sense.

5. Answer D Concept 4

A linguist ~~who has recorded speech in 12 communities~~ notes that many English speakers say “Who did you call?” though some style guides require “Whom did you call?” ~~The recordings were made over five years.~~ Which statement reflects a descriptive view?

Target word: descriptive vs. prescriptive **Decides:** Descriptive grammar reports actual usage.

A	Inverted operation	A prescriptive rule.
B	Absolute language	All speakers follow a grammar.
C	Adjacent category	The who/whom choice is a grammatical form.
D	Correct	Describes actual use without judging it.

6. Answer B Concept 4 • transfer

Which statement is an example of prescriptive grammar?

Target word: identify prescriptive **Decides:** Prescriptive grammar tells people how they should speak or write.

A	Inverted operation	That describes usage.
B	Correct	A rule about what speakers should do.
C	Confusion set	A description of a regular pattern.
D	Adjacent category	A claim about acquisition, not a usage rule.

7. Answer D Concept 5

A student ~~whose family runs a bakery~~ consistently says “She be working after school” to mean she regularly works then. ~~The student sits near the classroom window.~~ How should the teacher view and respond to this?

Target word: view of dialect **Decides:** Habitual “be” is a systematic feature of a dialect.

A	Inverted operation	The goal is adding a register, not replacing the home one.
B	Absolute language	Misreads a systematic feature as a lack of grammar.
C	Confusion set	It is consistent and meaningful, not random.
D	Correct	Adds a register without devaluing the dialect.

8. Answer A Concept 5 • transfer

A student uses her home dialect with friends at lunch and standard academic English in a class presentation. What does this show?

Target word: name the practice **Decides:** Switching language varieties to fit the setting.

A	Correct	Choosing the variety for the context is a strength.
B	Inverted operation	Her choices are deliberate and fit the setting.
C	Absolute language	Dialects are full systems.
D	Adjacent category	Fossilization is stalled development, not choosing a register.

9. Answer A Concept 6

A newcomer from a culture where children show respect by looking down when an adult speaks avoids eye contact with his teacher. ~~He arrived in January and joined the soccer team.~~ The teacher thinks he is being disrespectful. What is the best interpretation?

Target word: culture in communication **Decides:** Looking down is a respect norm in his culture.

A	Correct	Language use is shaped by culture.
B	Camouflage	The team is irrelevant; the behavior has a cultural explanation.
C	Adjacent category	Eye contact is a cultural norm, not a comprehension issue.
D	Inverted operation	Reads a respect norm as its opposite.

10. Answer A Concept 7

A researcher ~~with a lab of four graduate students~~ notes that toddlers say things like “Mommy sock” and “allgone milk,” phrases adults never say. ~~The study used a new recording app.~~ Which theory does this evidence support most?

Target word: match evidence to theory **Decides:** Children produce forms they never heard.

A	Correct	Novel forms cannot come from copying adults.
B	Adjacent category	Interaction matters, but this evidence is about novel grammar.
C	Inverted operation	Adults do not say these phrases, so imitation cannot explain them.
D	Camouflage	Such forms are widely documented.

11. Answer C Concept 7 · transfer

Which piece of evidence best supports behaviorist theory?

Target word: evidence for the other theory (reverse) **Decides:** Behaviorism relies on imitation and reinforcement.

A	Adjacent category	Evidence for sociocultural interaction.
B	Inverted operation	Evidence for rule-building, not imitation.
C	Correct	Reinforcement shaping a behavior.
D	Confusion set	Evidence for an innate capacity.

12. Answer C Concept 8

A Spanish-speaking learner ~~who writes in a journal every morning~~ often writes “the car red” and “a house big.” ~~Her teacher uses a color-coded grammar chart.~~ What is the best explanation?

Target word: syntactic transfer **Decides:** Spanish typically places adjectives after nouns.

A	Absolute language	Transfer can also be positive, as with cognates and shared patterns.
B	Dropped element	She uses the words correctly; only the order differs.
C	Correct	The error mirrors first-language syntax.
D	Confusion set	No English rule puts adjectives after nouns this way.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	3	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	9	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	8	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	7	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	4	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Morphemes: free, bound, inflectional, derivational	A morpheme is the smallest unit of meaning; derivational morphemes make new words or change word class, while inflectional morphemes mark grammar (tense, number) without changing class.	Counting syllables as morphemes, or calling every suffix inflectional.	“How many morphemes?” or “what kind of suffix?”
2	Syntax and structural ambiguity	One string of words can have two structures (different phrase groupings), giving two meanings.	Blaming ambiguity on a single word’s meaning when it comes from structure.	A sentence that can be read two ways with no ambiguous word.
3	Semantics: denotation, connotation, and multiple meanings	Denotation is literal meaning; connotation is the attitude a word carries. Polysemous words have related senses that ELLs must learn in context.	Teaching one dictionary meaning as if it covers every use.	A word used in a school subject with a meaning different from everyday use.
4	Descriptive vs. prescriptive grammar	Descriptive grammar describes how speakers actually use language; prescriptive grammar states rules for a formal standard.	Treating any non-standard form as having no grammar.	A judgment about whether a form is “correct.”
5	Dialects are rule-governed	Every dialect has systematic grammar; teachers add the academic register (code-switching by context) without devaluing the home dialect.	Calling a dialect “broken” or “lazy” English.	A student’s consistent non-standard form, such as habitual “be.”
6	Language and culture	Cultural norms shape how language is used (eye contact, turn-taking, directness); social language develops faster than academic language.	Reading a cultural communication norm as disrespect, or taking conversational fluency as academic readiness.	A behavior that differs from classroom expectations, or a fluent talker who struggles with textbooks.
7	Theories of first-language acquisition	Behaviorist theory credits imitation and reinforcement; nativist theory credits an innate capacity for grammar; sociocultural theory credits interaction with more skilled others.	Matching evidence to the wrong theory, such as using novel child errors to support imitation.	A piece of evidence and “which theory does it support?”
8	Syntactic transfer from the first language	First-language grammar can transfer positively (shared patterns) or negatively (different patterns), such as adjective–noun order.	Assuming all first-language influence is negative.	An error pattern that mirrors the learner’s first-language word order.

Course scope (public description): Theories of Second Language Learning Acquisition and Grammar covers content material in applied linguistics, including morphology, syntax, semantics, and grammar. Students will explore the role of dialect in the classroom, the connections between language and culture, and the theories of first and second language acquisition.